Irregular and ill-distributed rains were reported in October but with no relevant effect on the normal development of the 1997/98 second season cereal and bean crops. The first season crops had been seriously affected by El Niño-related dry weather and about 125 000 tons of white maize were lost. Despite a slight recovery in the second season crop, production of maize is forecast to decline from last year's above-average 630 000 tons to a low 506 000 tons. Sorghum output, by contrast, is expected to be about average as the bulk of the crop is collected from the second season crop. Only minor damage has been reported to the bean crop and an average output is anticipated. Despite losses incurred, supplies and prices of basic grains in the country have remained stable mainly due to the prompt action taken by the Government in the management of strategic reserves and increased imports. In an effort to help the drought affected farmers, technical assistance has been provided and new credit funds and conditions have been granted through the Ministry of Agriculture for the refinancing of crops.

Wheat imports in marketing year 1997/98 (August/July) are expected to increase slightly from the previous year's receipts of about 195 000 tons. By contrast, imports of maize should increase from 190 000 tons to about 300 000 tons to help cover the deficit in production. Rice imports in 1998 (January/December) should be close to 1997 imports of 23 000 tons.

GUATEMALA (20 November)

Adverse weather continue to affect the developing 1997/98 second season cereal and bean crops. These were affected by seasonal hurricane rains and heavy flooding in the south-central province of Escuintla in late September, and by dry weather again in October. The output of maize, the main crop, for both seasons is expected to decline from last year's below average 1.1 million tons to 900 000 tons. This is mainly the result of first season crop losses caused by El Niño-related drought. Lesser damage is reported to the modest paddy crop and output should be slightly below-average. Localized losses are reported to the bean crop. In an effort to cope with the continuing effect of El Niño, contingency planning has been adopted by various Ministries and institutions, such as the financing of small irrigation systems, improvements of rural roads, control of strategic grain reserves, improvement in the dissemination of adequate weather information and other protective measures.

Wheat imports in marketing year 1997/98 (November/October) are likely to decline from last year's receipts of 320 000 tons to some 275 000 tons, mostly as a consequence large carry-over stocks. Maize imports (July/June) should increase from 400 000 tons to about 610 000 tons in order to cover the deficit in production and thus meet the strong domestic demand. Rice imports in 1998 (January/December) should be about 35 000 to 40 000 tons.

HAITI* (18 November)

Harvesting of the 1997 second season irrigated paddy crop has started under adequate weather conditions. The crop was significantly affected during the first half of the year as a consequence of a prolonged drought which affected all crops. Output for the year should decline from the below-average 80 000 tons of the previous year. Planting of the bean crop has just started and a slight recovery is expected. The output of vegetables has been satisfactory.

HONDURAS (20 November)

Harvesting of the 1997/98 second season (main) maize and paddy crops is underway while that of beans has been recently completed under generally dry weather. Localized losses, particularly in the depressed areas of the south, were incurred to the first season crops by the early effects of El Niño, but increases in production were obtained in the main producing areas of the country which helped compensate for the losses reported. Maize output is provisionally forecast at an average 595 000 tons, while average sorghum production is anticipated. In order to cope with the potential impact of El Niño in the next few months, the Government has undertaken some protective measures including the construction of small irrigation systems and temporary water reservoirs, the drilling of wells and the sale of water pumps. Assistance from the international community has been received, mainly in the form of food aid distribution to the affected southern rural population and funds for the purchase of fertilizers.